



HUSTLE STUDIO TOOLKIT

# A Very Merry Murder

A printable cozy Christmas murder mystery party game for 6-12 players

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# Start Here

**A Very Merry Murder** is a printable murder mystery party game for 6 to 12 players (up to 16 if guests pair up on roles). Everything you need is in this PDF. Print it, hand out the booklets and play.

It is a *cozy* mystery. There is no gore and no adult content, so it works for family Christmas, friends' get-togethers and office parties alike. Every role can be played by anyone: the names and costumes are gender-neutral.

## The story in one paragraph

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It is Christmas Eve at Snowbury Lodge, and the Frost & Fable Toy Company is having its annual party. The founder, **Nicholas "Nick" Frost**, raises his favourite red mug for the 9 o'clock toast. Forty minutes later he collapses beside the Christmas tree and never wakes up. The snow has closed the only road. Nobody can leave, and somebody in the room did it. **Inspector Noel** (that's you, the host) has until morning to find out who.

## What's in this kit

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| Part                    | What it is                                                                              | Print                  |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Host Guide              | Prep checklist, cast list, how to scale for 6-12 players, run sheet, read-aloud scripts | 1 copy, for you        |
| Cast List & Invitations | Character blurbs, costume ideas, invitation wording                                     | 1 copy                 |
| 12 Character Booklets   | One per role: who you are, your secret, what to do in each round                        | 1 per player           |
| 12 Evidence Cards       | Revealed by the host over three rounds                                                  | 1 set, cut out         |
| Accusation Ballots      | Who, how, why                                                                           | 1 per player           |
| Solution & Reveal       | The full answer, the clue chain and the closing speech                                  | Host only, keep sealed |

## How the game works

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1. **Before the party:** you assign a character to each guest and send their invitation (costume idea included).
2. **Opening scene (5 min):** you read the opening script. Nick has just collapsed.
3. **Three rounds (25-30 min each):** guests mingle in character, question each other and follow the instructions in their booklet. At the start of each round you reveal new evidence cards.
4. **Accusations (10 min):** everyone fills in a ballot: who did it, how, and why.
5. **The reveal (5 min):** you read the solution. Award prizes for best detective and best costume.

Total playing time: about **2 to 2.5 hours**, including a dinner or snack break.

## Can the host play too?

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Yes. The host plays **Inspector Noel**, who runs the rounds, reads the scripts and asks questions. You'll know the answer, so you're not competing to guess, but you're in the story all evening and not stuck in the kitchen.

## Is it fair?

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Yes. The culprit can be worked out from the evidence cards alone, without needing any one guest to be present. Every suspect has a motive and a secret, and every innocent suspect is cleared by at least one piece of evidence. The full clue chain is in the Solution chapter, so you can check it yourself.

## Printing tips

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- Print the whole PDF in black and white; it's designed to read clearly without colour.
- Works on US Letter and A4 paper. Choose "Fit to page" in your print dialog.
- Print the Solution chapter last and keep it away from guests.

*Clue & Candle Games. An original story; any resemblance to real people or companies is coincidental. Written with AI assistance with every clue checked against the solution.*

# Host Guide

You don't need any experience to host this. Follow this chapter from top to bottom.

## Two weeks before: prep checklist

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- ☐ Count your guests and choose the cast with the table below.
- ☐ Assign a character to each guest. Give the **Robin Holly** role to a guest who will enjoy keeping a straight face, and never play Robin yourself.
- ☐ Send invitations (wording in the next chapter) with each guest's character name and costume idea.
- ☐ Print: 1 booklet per player, 1 set of evidence cards (cut out), 1 ballot per player, this guide.
- ☐ Put each booklet in an envelope with the character's name on the front. Players must not read other booklets.
- ☐ Optional: a red mug, a small bottle tied with red ribbon, a wooden toy and a "Snowbury Lodge" sign for the table.

## Choosing the cast

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The six **core** characters are always needed. Add optional characters in the order below. All the key evidence is on the evidence cards, so the mystery stays solvable however many optional characters you use.

| Players | Cast                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 6       | Core only: Robin Holly, Jordan Tinsel, Sam Garland, Casey Sleigh, Alex Snow, Morgan Ivy                                                                                                                                                                       |
| 7       | + Taylor Star (the hired Santa)                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| 8       | + Charlie Bell (marketing manager)                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| 9       | + Frankie Fir (the gardener)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 10      | + Quinn Mistletoe (the journalist)                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| 11      | + Jamie Pudding (the village baker)                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 12      | + Riley Carol (the hired pianist)                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 13-16   | Use all 12 roles and let couples or friends <b>share a role</b> as a pair: two Caseys from Sleigh Bells Catering, two Taylors as Santa and an elf, and so on. Or extra guests can play <b>Deputy Detectives</b> who help Inspector Noel and fill in a ballot. |

**Robin Holly is the culprit.** That's why you must not play Robin yourself.

## Run sheet (about 2.5 hours)

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| Time | What happens                            | You do                                                                            |
|------|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0:00 | Guests arrive, drinks, costumes, photos | Hand out envelopes. Players read <b>"Before the game"</b> and <b>Round 1</b> only |
| 0:15 | Opening scene                           | Read <b>Script 1</b>                                                              |
| 0:20 | Round 1                                 | Reveal <b>Evidence 1-4</b> . Players mingle and question each other               |
| 0:50 | Dinner or snacks                        | Players stay in character if they like                                            |
| 1:20 | Round 2                                 | Read <b>Script 2</b> , reveal <b>Evidence 5-8</b> . Players read Round 2          |
| 1:50 | Round 3                                 | Read <b>Script 3</b> , reveal <b>Evidence 9-12</b> . Players read Round 3         |
| 2:20 | Accusations                             | Read <b>Script 4</b> . Hand out ballots, 5-10 minutes to fill them in             |
| 2:30 | The reveal                              | Read the <b>Solution</b> chapter. Give out awards                                 |

How to reveal evidence: read the card aloud, then put it face up on a table where everyone can look at it.

## Read-aloud scripts

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### Script 1: Opening (read as Inspector Noel)

"Good evening, everyone. My name is Inspector Noel. I came to Snowbury Lodge tonight as somebody's plus-one, for eggnog and carols. I did not come to work.

But twenty minutes ago, at 9:40, our host Nicholas Frost, founder of the Frost & Fable Toy Company, collapsed beside the Christmas tree. I'm sorry to tell you that Nick has died. He was perfectly well at the 9 o'clock toast.

The snow has closed the road, the phone lines are down, and nobody is leaving this lodge tonight. I believe one of you knows exactly what happened to Nick. Each of you has a secret, and I intend to hear all of them.

Talk to each other. Ask questions. You can keep your own secrets for now, but you may not lie about the evidence. Here's what we know so far."

*(Reveal Evidence 1-4.)*

### Script 2: Start of Round 2

"Thank you all for your patience, and for the sausage rolls. While you ate, I did some digging. The lodge keeps a key log, the gardener keeps a diary, and Nick kept secrets of his own. Let's see what they tell us."

*(Reveal Evidence 5-8.)*

### Script 3: Start of Round 3

"It's almost midnight. The snow has stopped, and I've been outside with a torch. I found something in the snow, and something else in a drawer where it should not have been. This is the last round. Choose your questions carefully."

*(Reveal Evidence 9-12.)*

## Script 4: Accusations

"Time's up. Each of you will now write down who killed Nicholas Frost, how they did it and why. Even the guilty party must fill in a ballot. Fold it up and hand it to me. Then I'll tell you what really happened at Snowbury Lodge."

## Hosting tips

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- **Quiet guest?** Ask them a direct question from their booklet: "Taylor, you were by the tree all evening. What did you see?"
- **Someone gets stuck?** Remind everyone that each booklet says what to reveal in each round.
- **Moving too fast?** Spend more time on the food. Each round only needs 15 minutes if your group is quick.
- **Prizes:** Best Detective (most of who, how and why right), Best Costume, Best Liar (usually Robin).

# Cast, Invitations & Character Booklets

## Invitation wording (copy into a card, email or message)

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**You are invited to the Frost & Fable Christmas Eve Party at Snowbury Lodge.** Date: \_\_\_\_ · Time: \_\_\_\_ · Place: \_\_\_\_ You will be playing: **[CHARACTER NAME], [ROLE]** Costume idea: [from the cast list] Come in character. Someone at this party won't make it to Christmas morning...

## Cast list (safe for everyone to see)

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| Character                     | Role                                          | Costume idea                                          |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Robin Holly                   | Head toymaker, 15 years at Frost & Fable      | Green apron, reading glasses, a pencil behind the ear |
| Jordan Tinsel                 | Finance director and Nick's business partner  | Sharp suit, tinsel scarf, calculator                  |
| Sam Garland                   | Nick's nephew or niece, a struggling novelist | Cosy cardigan, notebook, scarf                        |
| Casey Sleigh                  | Owner of Sleigh Bells Catering                | White apron, chef's hat, ladle                        |
| Alex Snow                     | Rival toymaker from Snow Toys, uninvited      | All white, frosty silver accessories                  |
| Morgan Ivy                    | Nick's personal assistant                     | Smart outfit, clipboard, a ring of keys               |
| Taylor Star <i>(opt.)</i>     | Hired party Santa                             | Santa suit, or an elf costume                         |
| Charlie Bell <i>(opt.)</i>    | Marketing manager                             | Bright festive jumper, camera or phone                |
| Frankie Fir <i>(opt.)</i>     | The lodge gardener                            | Flannel shirt, wellies, garden gloves                 |
| Quinn Mistletoe <i>(opt.)</i> | Reporter for <i>Toy Trade Weekly</i>          | Trench coat, press badge                              |
| Jamie Pudding <i>(opt.)</i>   | Village baker and Nick's ex                   | Flour-dusted apron, gingerbread brooch                |
| Riley Carol <i>(opt.)</i>     | Hired pianist                                 | Bow tie or velvet, sheet music                        |

**The victim:** Nicholas "Nick" Frost, founder of the Frost & Fable Toy Company. Generous in public, ruthless in business. Loved anything peppermint.

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## How to use your booklet (all players)

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Read "**Before the game**" and **Round 1** when you arrive. Read each later round only when Inspector Noel starts it. You may keep your secret until your booklet tells you to reveal it. You

may not lie about anything shown on an evidence card, unless your booklet says otherwise.

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## Booklet: Robin Holly, Head Toymaker

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**Before the game.** You've carved toys in the Snowbury workshop for 15 years. Your Jingle Bear is the best-selling toy Frost & Fable ever made. Everyone knows you love Christmas, plants and the old ways of making things.

**YOUR SECRET: YOU KILLED NICK.** At about 3:30 you took a new prototype, a dancing nutcracker, to Nick's study. The door was ajar. You heard Nick and Jordan agree to sell the company to MegaMart: the workshop closes on 15 January, and every design you ever made, the Jingle Bear included, now belongs to MegaMart. Nick laughed and said, "Robin's a sentimental fool. The designs belong to the company anyway." You left the nutcracker on the hall table and walked away.

At 4:00 you signed out the greenhouse key "for holly" and cut three foxglove stalks (your grandmother taught you which plants are poisonous). You borrowed a small saucepan and peppermint extract from Casey's kitchen, and in the workshop kitchenette you boiled the foxglove into a "peppermint syrup". You poured it into an antique bottle, tied it with red velvet ribbon and wrote the tag. You had drawn Nick in the Secret Santa, so at 6:45 you put it under the tree as your gift. At 9:00 Nick poured it into his eggnog. After he collapsed you took the bottle and dropped it out of the workshop window into the snow.

**Your cover story:** you gave Nick a hand-carved wooden reindeer for Secret Santa. You may lie about the crime. Don't confess until Inspector Noel reveals the solution.

**Round 1.** Be warm and shocked: Nick was "like family". Point out that Jordan handed Nick his mug and Casey made the eggnog. If anyone asks what you gave for Secret Santa, it was the reindeer.

**Round 2.** About the key log: you fetched holly for the mantel (there really is holly on the mantel). About the Secret Santa list: "Yes, I drew Nick, and I gave him the reindeer. Someone must have swapped the gifts." Steer suspicion to Morgan, who ran the Secret Santa and also had the greenhouse key.

**Round 3.** About the reindeer in your drawer: "I wanted to give it to him privately, later." About the bottle: anyone could have thrown it from that window. Keep pushing Morgan and Alex.

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## Booklet: Jordan Tinsel, Finance Director

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**Before the game.** You've been Nick's business partner for ten years. You're the numbers person. At the 9:00 toast, you carried Nick's red mug from the kitchen to him. Casey had filled it from the eggnog bowl.

**Your secret.** Two years ago you "borrowed" \$20,000 from the company's charity Toy Drive fund to cover a reindeer-farm investment that failed. Nick found out last week. He said you'd repay it from your sale bonus or he'd go to the police. You also spent 3:00 to 5:00 today in the study with Nick, signing the sale of Frost & Fable to MegaMart. Nobody else is supposed to know about the sale yet.

**You are innocent.** Your alibi: you were in the study with Nick from 3:00 to 5:00, so you couldn't have gone to the greenhouse.

**Round 1.** Admit you carried the mug, but you never opened it and Casey poured it. Keep the sale and the charity fund secret. Ask Alex why they turned up uninvited. Ask Robin what they gave Nick for Secret Santa.

**Round 2.** When your meeting notes are revealed, admit the sale. Add this: at about 3:30 you heard the hall floorboards creak and smelled sawdust and wood varnish, as though someone had been standing outside the door.

**Round 3.** If pressed about money, confess the charity fund. Insist that Nick alive was your only way to repay it quietly. With Nick dead, the sale might fall through.

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## Booklet: Sam Garland, Nick's Nephew or Niece

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**Before the game.** You're Nick's only family, so you're his heir. You write mystery novels that nobody has published yet. You arrived on the 6:05 train.

**Your secret.** You're deep in debt, and last month Nick refused to lend you money ("Get a real job, Sam"). Your notebook is full of research for your novel *Death by Mistletoe*, and that includes notes on poisonous plants. Foxglove is one of them.

**You are innocent.** Your alibi: your train didn't arrive until 6:05.

**Round 1.** Be charming. Ask people whether Nick ever talked about his will. If your notebook page comes up, say it's research for chapter 9 and you're a writer, not a poisoner. You haven't been near the greenhouse.

**Round 2.** Share something you noticed: at the 8:30 Secret Santa opening, when Nick held up a little bottle with a red ribbon and said "Peppermint! Someone knows me!", Robin looked away and went very quiet.

**Round 3.** Admit the debt if pressed. Point out that the gardener's log means the foxglove was cut before 5:00, when you were still on the train.

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## Booklet: Casey Sleigh, Caterer

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**Before the game.** You run Sleigh Bells Catering. You made tonight's food and the big bowl of eggnog. You filled Nick's red mug from that bowl just before the toast.

**Your secret.** Nick never paid last year's \$4,000 catering bill. When you asked, he threatened to tell everyone your food made his guests ill, which wasn't true. You've been furious with him for months.

**You are innocent.**

**Round 1.** Defend your eggnog: everyone drank it all night and nobody else is ill. Share what you saw: at 9:00 Nick took a little glass bottle with a red velvet ribbon and poured it into his mug, saying "My Secret Santa knows me!" After he collapsed, the bottle was gone.

**Round 2.** Admit the unpaid bill if asked. Ask Morgan who drew Nick in the Secret Santa.

**Round 3.** Remember this now: at about 4:45 Robin came to your kitchen and borrowed a small saucepan and your peppermint extract "for a workshop project". You thought it was for gingerbread glue. You never got the saucepan back.

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## Booklet: Alex Snow, Rival Toymaker

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**Before the game.** You run Snow Toys, Frost & Fable's biggest rival. Nobody invited you. You arrived by taxi at 7:15.

**Your secret.** Twelve years ago Nick stole your Snowflake Sled design and made a fortune from it. You heard a rumour that Frost & Fable was for sale, and you came tonight to make Nick an offer, or to make a scene. At about 8:00, in front of several guests, you said: "You'll regret this, Frost!"

**You are innocent.** Your alibi: your taxi picked you up in town at 6:50.

**Round 1.** Be frosty but polite. Admit you weren't invited. Deny threatening anyone, until someone mentions it.

**Round 2.** Admit the stolen Snowflake Sled. Say that you wanted Nick ruined, not dead: a dead man can't sign a deal with you.

**Round 3.** Share this: at about 9:45, while everyone crowded around Nick, you stepped into the corridor for air. You saw someone in a **green apron** at the workshop window, opening it. You couldn't see their face.

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## **Booklet: Morgan Ivy, Personal Assistant**

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**Before the game.** You've organised Nick's life for six years. You planned tonight's party and ran the Secret Santa draw, and you keep the list. You hold most of the lodge keys.

**Your secret.** This morning Nick told you that you're out of a job in January, because MegaMart has its own assistants. Also, at 6:00 you signed out the greenhouse key to fetch poinsettias for the tables.

**You are innocent.** The foxglove was cut before 5:00, and you didn't go to the greenhouse until 6:00.

**Round 1.** Keep the party calm. Admit you ran the Secret Santa, but don't say who drew whom: "It's a secret!"

**Round 2.** Once the list is revealed, confirm it's genuine and that nobody could have changed it. Mention that at 5:00 the gardener told you some foxgloves had been cut. You assumed deer had got in.

**Round 3.** Admit you were being let go if pressed. Point out that your greenhouse visit was at 6:00, an hour after the foxgloves were found cut.

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## **Booklet: Taylor Star, Hired Santa *(optional)***

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**Before the game.** You're an actor hired to play Santa tonight. You've been beside the tree all evening.

**Your secret.** A MegaMart executive paid you \$200 to report any gossip from the party. You've been texting them all night.

**You are innocent.**

**Round 1.** Stay jolly. Admit you were by the tree from 6:30.

**Round 2.** Share what you saw: at about 6:45, while you were adjusting your beard, someone in a **green workshop apron** slipped a small box with a red velvet ribbon under the tree.

**Round 3.** Confess the MegaMart texts if pressed. They show that MegaMart wanted the deal to go through, and a dead Nick puts it at risk.

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## **Booklet: Charlie Bell, Marketing Manager *(optional)***

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**Before the game.** You run marketing for Frost & Fable and you've taken photos all night for the company newsletter.

**Your secret.** You leaked the sale rumour to Alex Snow last week, hoping Snow Toys would hire you.

**You are innocent.**

**Round 1.** Mention your photos. You have one of the toast at 9:00, with Nick holding his red mug.

**Round 2.** Admit the leak if anyone asks how Alex knew about the sale.

**Round 3.** Look through your photos: in the 9:50 group shot of the shocked guests, **Robin is missing**, and the red-ribboned bottle no longer sits by Nick's plate.

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## **Booklet: Frankie Fir, Lodge Gardener *(optional)***

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**Before the game.** You look after Snowbury Lodge's grounds and greenhouse, and you have your own greenhouse key.

**Your secret.** You've been quietly selling the lodge's prize poinsettias to the village florist.

**You are innocent.** You were in the village from 3:15 to 4:50, and you have a receipt.

**Round 1.** Explain that the greenhouse grows foxglove, which is lovely and very poisonous, and that only someone who knows plants would think of it.

**Round 2.** Confirm your log: all fine at 3:00, three foxglove stalks freshly cut at 5:00. You told Morgan.

**Round 3.** Add a detail: there was sawdust in the soil by the foxglove bed, and your greenhouse never has sawdust in it.

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## **Booklet: Quinn Mistletoe, Journalist *(optional)***

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**Before the game.** You write for *Toy Trade Weekly*. You came as a guest "for the eggnog".

**Your secret.** You're undercover, chasing the story of the MegaMart sale.

**You are innocent.**

**Round 1.** Ask everyone, casually, whether the company is changing hands.

**Round 2.** Reveal what your source told you: the sale contract says **all designs belong to the company**, so the Jingle Bear and every other toy Robin made go to MegaMart. Robin gets nothing.

**Round 3.** Admit why you're really here if pressed.

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## **Booklet: Jamie Pudding, Village Baker *(optional)***

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**Before the game.** You run Pudding's Bakery in the village. You and Nick were a couple years ago, and you parted on bad terms.

**Your secret.** Nick lent you the money to open the bakery and demanded it back this month.

**You are innocent.**

**Round 1.** Share a memory: Nick adored peppermint, though only people who'd known him for years knew how much.

**Round 2.** Tell people this: at 8:40 Nick told you, "Someone here really knows me. Peppermint syrup! Must be one of the old crew."

**Round 3.** Admit the loan if asked.

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## **Booklet: Riley Carol, Hired Pianist *(optional)***

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**Before the game.** You were hired to play carols all evening. The piano sits near the corridor to the workshop.

**Your secret.** You're secretly writing a jingle for Snow Toys, Alex's company.

**You are innocent.**

**Round 1.** Mention that you could see most of the room from the piano.

**Round 2.** Admit you know Alex, if asked.

**Round 3.** Share this: at about 9:45, just after Nick collapsed, you heard a window creak open at the workshop end of the corridor, and footsteps hurrying back.

# Evidence Cards, Ballots & Solution

## Evidence cards (cut out, reveal by round)

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### ROUND 1

**EVIDENCE 1: The doctor's note.** "Signs of foxglove (digitalis) poisoning. Symptoms usually begin 30 to 60 minutes after it's swallowed. Nick collapsed at 9:40, so he took the poison at about 9:00, around the time of the toast."

**EVIDENCE 2: The mug and the bowl.** Every guest drank from the eggnog bowl all evening, and nobody else is ill. Nick's red "Big Boss" mug holds eggnog, a strong smell of peppermint and tiny green flecks with a bitter, grassy smell.

**EVIDENCE 3: The gift tag.** Found under Nick's chair: *"Peppermint syrup, just for you, Nick! Merry Christmas from your Secret Santa."* It's handwritten in pencil. The bottle it came with is missing.

**EVIDENCE 4: A notebook page.** Found in a cardigan pocket by the fire: *"Foxglove: pretty, deadly, perfect for chapter 9. Bitter taste, so hide it in something sweet?"* The handwriting is Sam Garland's.

### ROUND 2

**EVIDENCE 5: The greenhouse key log** (hanging in the hall).

- 4:00 to 4:30 pm: **Robin Holly**, "holly for the mantel"
- 6:00 to 6:15 pm: **Morgan Ivy**, "poinsettias for tables"

*Note: the greenhouse has only two keys. One hangs on this hook; the gardener, Frankie Fir, carries the other.*

**EVIDENCE 6: The gardener's log.** "3:00 pm: all plants fine. Off to the village for supplies. 5:00 pm: back. Three foxglove stalks cut clean off, the cut ends still wet. Told Morgan, probably deer?" Stapled to it: a receipt from Snowbury Garden Supply, timed **4:20 pm**.

**EVIDENCE 7: The Secret Santa list** (in Morgan's handwriting). Robin Holly → **Nick Frost** · Nick Frost → Sam Garland · Sam Garland → Morgan Ivy · Morgan Ivy → Jordan Tinsel · Jordan Tinsel → Casey Sleigh · Casey Sleigh → Robin Holly. *"Other guests: separate guest gift swap. Gifts under the tree by 7 pm!"*

**EVIDENCE 8: Meeting notes from Nick's study.** "3:00 pm, Nick and Jordan. MegaMart purchase agreed and signed at 4:55. Snowbury workshop closes 15 January. All product designs remain company property." On the hall table outside the study: a small wooden dancing nutcracker labelled *"For Nick, a new idea! R.H."*

### ROUND 3

**EVIDENCE 9: The bottle.** Found in the snow directly below the **workshop window**: an antique glass bottle tied with red velvet ribbon. Inside are sticky peppermint syrup and bitter green flecks. The window latch is open.

**EVIDENCE 10: The workbench drawer.** In the drawer of Robin Holly's workbench: a hand-carved wooden reindeer, still wrapped, tagged *"To Nick, from your Secret Santa."* It was never given.

**EVIDENCE 11: Travel receipts.** Sam Garland's train ticket: arrived Snowbury **6:05 pm**. Alex Snow's taxi receipt: picked up in town **6:50 pm**, dropped at the lodge **7:15 pm**.

**EVIDENCE 12: The saucepan.** In the workshop kitchenette sink: a small saucepan with a *Sleigh Bells Catering* label. It smells of peppermint and something green and bitter, and an empty bottle of peppermint extract sits next to it.

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## Accusation ballot (print one per player)

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Your character: \_\_\_\_\_

Who killed Nicholas Frost? \_\_\_\_\_

How was it done? \_\_\_\_\_

Why? \_\_\_\_\_

The clue that convinced you: \_\_\_\_\_

*Scoring (optional): 3 points for who, 1 for how, 1 for why. Most points wins Best Detective.*

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## SOLUTION (host only: do not read before the party)

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### Who did it

**Robin Holly**, the head toymaker, poisoned Nick with foxglove hidden in a homemade "peppermint syrup", given to him as a Secret Santa gift.

### The clue chain (how players can prove it)

1. **The poison was in the syrup, not the eggnog.** Nobody else who drank the eggnog fell ill (E2). Nick added the syrup to his own mug at 9:00 (Casey's statement; E3). Timing fits a 9:00 poisoning (E1). This clears **Casey**, who made the eggnog, and **Jordan**, who only carried the mug.
2. **The syrup was Nick's Secret Santa gift, and Robin drew Nick** (E3, E7). Taylor saw someone in a green workshop apron put the red-ribboned box under the tree at 6:45.
3. **Only Robin could get the foxglove.** It was cut between 3:00 and 5:00 (E6). The only key logged out in that window was Robin's, 4:00 to 4:30 (E5). The gardener holds the other key but was in the village (receipt 4:20, E6). Morgan's visit was at 6:00, too late. Sam was on the train until 6:05 and Alex was in town until 6:50 (E11). Jordan was in the study with Nick from 3:00 to 5:00 (E8).
4. **Robin made the syrup.** Casey's saucepan and peppermint extract ended up in the workshop kitchenette, smelling of peppermint and bitter greens (E12). Casey says Robin borrowed them at 4:45.
5. **Robin lied and got rid of the bottle.** The reindeer Robin "gave" Nick is still wrapped in Robin's drawer (E10). The poison bottle was thrown from the workshop window (E9), seen by Alex, heard by Riley, and confirmed by Robin's absence from Charlie's 9:50 photo.
6. **Motive.** Robin's nutcracker sat outside the study door at 3:30 (E8), when Jordan heard someone listening. Robin learned that the workshop would close and that every design Robin ever made would belong to MegaMart.

## Why the others didn't do it

| Suspect                              | Motive (red herring)                                | Cleared by                                             |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Jordan Tinsel                        | Stole from the charity fund; Nick threatened police | In the study with Nick 3:00-5:00; never opened the mug |
| Sam Garland                          | Heir; in debt; poison notes                         | On the train until 6:05; notes were novel research     |
| Casey Sleigh                         | Unpaid \$4,000 bill                                 | Eggnog was clean; saucepan was borrowed by Robin       |
| Alex Snow                            | Stolen Snowflake Sled design                        | In town until 6:50; gifts were under the tree by then  |
| Morgan Ivy                           | Being fired                                         | Greenhouse visit at 6:00, after the foxglove was cut   |
| Frankie Fir                          | Selling poinsettias                                 | In the village 3:15-4:50 (receipt)                     |
| Taylor, Charlie, Quinn, Jamie, Riley | Smaller secrets                                     | No greenhouse access and no link to the gift           |

## The reveal (read aloud as Inspector Noel)

"Nicholas Frost wasn't poisoned by the eggnog. Every one of us drank it. He was poisoned by a gift: a little bottle of peppermint syrup, made by someone who knew how much he loved peppermint.

That syrup was his Secret Santa present, and the Secret Santa list says Nick was drawn by **Robin Holly**. Robin, you told us you gave him a carved reindeer. But that reindeer is still wrapped in your workbench drawer.

The foxglove was cut between three and five o'clock. Only one name is on the key log in that window: yours, at four. You borrowed Casey's saucepan and peppermint extract at a quarter to five, and we found them in the workshop kitchenette. When Nick fell, you slipped away, opened the workshop window and threw the bottle into the snow. Alex saw a green apron at that window, Riley heard it open, and Charlie's photo shows you weren't with us.

And the reason? At half past three you stood outside Nick's study with a new toy in your hands, and you heard him sell your workshop, your Jingle Bear and fifteen years of your work to MegaMart, then call you a sentimental fool.

Robin Holly, you made toys to bring people joy. Tonight you made something else. Merry Christmas, everyone, and well done to our detectives."

*Now ask Robin to take a bow, read out the ballots and hand out the awards.*